

Philosophical Foundations — Module 07:

Communication — Study Questions

1. State the traditional problem of other minds. How does Active Inference address it through higher-order generative modeling?
2. Compare the argument from analogy, simulation theory, and theory-theory as solutions to the other minds problem. How does Active Inference's approach differ from each?
3. What is "active inference about active inference"? How does this implement mentalizing (theory of mind)?
4. Explain the speaker-listener loop in the language-as-active-inference hypothesis. How does EFE guide word selection?
5. How does Wittgenstein's "meaning is use" connect to Active Inference's account of language?
6. How can Grice's conversational maxims (quality, quantity, relation, manner) be derived from free energy minimization? Give a concrete example for each maxim.
7. What does it mean for communication to be "approximate"? Why can the listener's beliefs never exactly match the speaker's intent?
8. Define primary, secondary, and tertiary intersubjectivity. How does each level build on the previous one?
9. How does infant-caregiver interaction exemplify primary intersubjectivity in Active Inference terms?
10. What role does joint attention play in the development of shared generative models?
11. How does Active Inference account for Searle's institutional facts? What makes money "real"?
12. Can a corporation be an agent under Active Inference? What would its Markov Blanket, generative model, and free energy look like?
13. What is Gadamer's "fusion of horizons"? How does it map onto convergence of posteriors?
14. How does the hermeneutic circle relate to hierarchical inference? Give a concrete example.
15. What is the role of "prejudice" (pre-understanding) in Gadamer? How do priors formalize this concept?

16. How does Active Inference explain misunderstanding? What causes communication failure in formal terms?
17. How does cultural difference affect communication in Active Inference terms? What happens when agents have very different priors?
18. How does Active Inference address the private language argument? Why can't meaning be purely private?
19. How does social media alter the communication landscape from an Active Inference perspective? Consider echo chambers, misinformation, and filter bubbles.
20. Critically evaluate: Does formalizing communication as coupled inference capture what is genuinely important about human communication, or does it miss essential aspects (emotion, power, aesthetics)?